NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TEACHER: _____

KEY TOPIC 2 • 1569–1588

Challenges to Elizabeth at Home and Abroad, 1569–88



HISTORICAL PRIMARY RECORD: The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (c. 1588)

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EXAM FOCUS **Q1(a) Feature:** 2m [3 min] • **Q1(b) Feature:** 2m [3 min] • **Q2 Causation:** 12m [18 min] **TARGET GRADE:**

PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION FRAMEWORK • KEY TOPIC 2

4 MODULAR ENQUIRIES

TOPIC 2.1 • PLOTS AND REVOLTS AT HOME

- The reasons for, and significance of, the Revolt of the Northern Earls, 1569–70.
- The features and significance of the Ridolfi, Throckmorton and Babington plots. Walsingham and the use of spies.
- The reasons for, and significance of, Mary Queen of Scots' execution in 1587.

TOPIC 2.2 • RELATIONS WITH SPAIN

- Political, religious and commercial rivalry.
- The significance of privateering and the activities of Drake.

TOPIC 2.3 • OUTBREAK OF WAR WITH SPAIN, 1585–88

- Reasons for deteriorating relations with Spain: English direct involvement in the Netherlands and the actions of Robert Dudley.
- Drake and the raid on Cadiz: 'Singeing the King of Spain's beard'.

TOPIC 2.4 • THE ARMADA

- Spanish invasion plans. Key events of the Spanish Armada.
- The reasons for the English victory.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 1: CHRONOLOGICAL ANCHORS (KEY TOPIC 2)

Instructions: As you study each enquiry lesson, complete the timeline missions by sketching and annotating in the corresponding dual-coding sketchpads below.

NOV 1569 • Revolt of the Northern Earls

Key Topic 2.1

Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland march on Durham Cathedral, tear up English bibles, and restore the Latin Mass with 4,600 men. Royal troops march north; the rebellion collapses and Elizabeth executes 450 rebels to crush northern disobedience.

FEB 1570 • Papal Bull: Regnans in Excelsis

Key Topic 2.1

Pope Pius V issues the papal bull Regnans in Excelsis, excommunicating Elizabeth as a heretic and absolving all Catholic subjects of their oath of allegiance. This officially criminalizes Catholic loyalty and makes all active recusants potential traitors.

1577–1580 • Drake Circumnavigates the Globe

Key Topic 2.2

Francis Drake completes the second circumnavigation in history in the Golden Hind, raiding Spanish Pacific colonies and capturing the treasure galleon Cacafuego (£140,000 in silver). Elizabeth knights Drake at Deptford, escalating Anglo-Spanish commercial rivalry.

"1569: The Northern Earls marched with Catholic banners; Elizabeth responded with 450 executions."

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 2: CHRONOLOGICAL ANCHORS (KEY TOPIC 2)

Instructions: Complete the dual-coding sketches to permanently anchor these chronological turning points in long-term memory.

AUG 1585 • Treaty of Nonsuch (War in Netherlands)

Key Topic 2.3

Following the assassination of William of Orange and the French Treaty of Joinville, Elizabeth signs the Treaty of Nonsuch, sending Robert Dudley (Earl of Leicester) with 7,400 English soldiers to aid Dutch Protestant rebels against the Duke of Parma.

FEB 1587 • Execution of Mary, Queen of Scots

Key Topic 2.1

Walsingham's codebreaker Thomas Phelippes intercepts Babington's ciphers explicitly approved by Mary Stuart. Tried under the 1584 Bond of Association, Mary is found guilty of high treason and beheaded at Fotheringhay Castle on 8 February 1587.

JUL–AUG 1588 • Defeat of the Spanish Armada

Key Topic 2.4

Medina Sidonia sails 130 ships to ferry Parma's invasion army across the Channel. English fireships scatter the crescent formation at Calais Roads; agile galleons batter Spanish ships at Gravelines, and violent storms wreck half the fleet on Scottish and Irish rocks.

Why did Catholic plots fail to overthrow Elizabeth between 1569 and 1587?

1 NOV 1569–JAN 1570

The Revolt of the Northern Earls

- Latin Mass at Durham Cathedral
- Spanish Troops Fail to Land
- Four Hundred and Fifty Executions

Why did the Northern Earls fail to overthrow Elizabeth despite capturing Durham Cathedral?

2 1570–1571

Papal Bull & The Ridolfi Plot

- Regnans in Excelsis Excommunication
- Italian Banker Roberto Ridolfi Courier
- Norfolk Beheaded on Tower Hill

How did the 1570 Papal Bull transform the legal and political danger facing English Catholics?

3 1583–1584

The Throckmorton Plot & Bond of Association

- French Duke of Guise Invasion Plan
- Philip II Provides 200,000 Ducats
- Bond of Association Traitor Oath

Why did the discovery of the Throckmorton Plot lead to harsher anti-Catholic measures?

4 1586

The Babington Plot & Walsingham's Spies

- Letters in Waterproof Beer Barrels
- Phelippes Decodes Gallows Cipher
- Explicit Approval of Regicide

How did Walsingham use espionage and deciphered correspondence to trap Mary Stuart?

5 FEB 1587

The Execution of Mary, Queen of Scots

- Act for the Queen's Safety Trial
- Fotheringhay Castle Great Hall Block
- Divine Right Monarchical Martyrdom

Why was Elizabeth so reluctant to execute Mary Queen of Scots despite proven treason?

"Walsingham's codebreaker Thomas Phelippes decoded the beer barrel letters: detail matters!"

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 18 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 2 (1HI0/2B) Score: / 12

Explain why Mary, Queen of Scots was executed in 1587. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer: • The Babington Plot • The Treaty of Nonsuch ***(You must also use information of your own.)***

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:
One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:
Anthony Babington • Francis Walsingham • Thomas Phelippes • Decoded Cipher Letters • Beer Barrel Courier • Bond of Association (1584) • Fotheringhay Castle • High Treason • Regnans in Excelsis

Write your response in the space provided below: *(Response continues on facing page)*

Score: / 12

Conclude your question 2 explain why and provide your sustained historical verdict below:

• QUESTION 1 PRACTICE: DESCRIBE ONE FEATURE [2 × 2M = 4 MARKS • 6 MINS]

Q1 Total: / 4

Q1(A) EDEXCEL JUNE 2019 (Q1A) — Mark: / 2

Describe one feature of the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569). [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this was evident when...*

Q1(B) EDEXCEL NOVEMBER 2021 (Q1A) — Mark: / 2

Describe one feature of the Babington Plot (1586). [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this meant that...*

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Milestone 5). In Milestone 5, sketch the beer barrel with hidden cipher letters and the execution block at Fotheringhay. ← Pages 2–3

"Forensic detail: the Bond of Association (1584) sealed Mary Stuart's fate before Babington wrote."

Was war between England and Spain inevitable from the moment Elizabeth took the throne?

1 1570–1577
Political and Religious Rivalry with Spain
- Antwerp Deep-Water Ports Threat
- William of Orange Protestant Rebellion
- Funding Sea Beggars Privateers

Why did Spanish control of the Netherlands threaten English trade and security?

2 1570–1579
Commercial Rivalry in the New World
- Spanish Monopoly on American Bullion
- Nombre de Dios Mule Train Ambush
- Queen Licences Legal Piracy

Why did English privateering in the Caribbean inflame diplomatic tensions with Spain?

3 1577–1580
Drake's Circumnavigation
- Cacafuego Surrenders £140,000 Treasure
- Uncharted Pacific Raids on Peru
- Golden Hind Knighthood Defiance

Why did Drake's circumnavigation represent a direct challenge to the Spanish Empire?

4 1581–1584
Escalation & Elizabeth's Defiance
- Philip II Inherits Portuguese Crown
- Assassination of William of Orange
- French Catholic Guise League Accord

How did events in Europe between 1580 and 1584 increase the threat of a Spanish invasion?

5 1584–1585
The Treaties of Joinville & Nonsuch
- Secret Treaty of Joinville (Dec 1584)
- 7,400 English Troops under Dudley
- Direct Military Confrontation Declared

Why did the Treaty of Nonsuch mark the point of no return for war between England and Spain?

Question 3: Evaluative Essay [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG • 25 mins]

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 (1HI0/2B)

Score: / 20

"Commercial rivalry was the main cause of conflict between England and Spain in the years 1576–85." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG]

You may use in your answer: • Drake's raid on the West Indies • Religious differences ***(You must also use information of your own.)***

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

To a large extent, it can be argued that... • A decisive factor supporting this view was... • Specifically, this was important because... • On the other hand, an alternative perspective is that... • In particular, ... • In conclusion, the decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Privateering • Francis Drake • Golden Hind • Cacafuego Treasure (£140,000) • Spanish Monopoly • New World Silver • King Philip II • Papal Excommunication • Atlantic Trade

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

Enquiry 2.2: Relations with Spain and commercial rivalry • Question 3 Evaluative Essay Continued

Score: / 20

Conclude your question 3 evaluative essay and provide your sustained historical verdict below:

• QUESTION 1 PRACTICE: DESCRIBE ONE FEATURE [2 × 2M = 4 MARKS • 6 MINS]

Q1 Total: / 4

Q1(A) **EDEXCEL SPECIFICATION FOCUS** **Mark: / 2**

Describe one feature of English privateering against Spain. [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this was evident when...*

Q1(B) **EDEXCEL JUNE 2018 (Q1B)** **Mark: / 2**

Describe one feature of Francis Drake's raid on Cadiz (1587). [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this meant that...*

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Milestone 2). In Milestone 2, sketch Francis Drake's Golden Hind carrying Spanish silver into Plymouth harbour. ← **Pages 2–3**

Why did English intervention in the Netherlands force Philip II to launch the Armada?

1 DEC 1585–1586

Dudley's Campaign in the Netherlands

- Governor-General Title Angers Elizabeth
- Underfunded & Deserting English Troops
- Prevents Parma Capturing Deep Ports

Why did Dudley's campaign in the Netherlands struggle to achieve decisive military success?

2 1586–1587

Military Setbacks: Zutphen & Deventer

- Sir Philip Sidney Killed at Zutphen
- Stanley & Yorke Betray Dutch Forts
- Dutch Council of State Distrust

How did English betrayals and command disputes damage relations with the Dutch rebels?

3 APRIL 1587

Drake's Raid on Cadiz

- Thirty Spanish Warships Destroyed
- 'Singeing the King of Spain's Beard'
- Postpones Armada by Twelve Months

How did Drake's tactical boldness at Cadiz disrupt the Spanish invasion timetable?

4 1587–1588

Impact of the Cadiz Raid

- Seasoned Barrel Staves Incinerated
- Santa Cruz Dies; Medina Sidonia Inexperienced
- Rotting Food & Leaking Water Casks

Why were logistical damage and command changes fatal to the Spanish invasion plan?

5 MAY–JULY 1588

The Armada Sets Sail

- 130 Ships & 30,000 Men Sail
- Parma Lacks Deep-Water Harbor in Shallows
- Unreliable 48-Hour Message Relay

What strategic flaws made Philip II's plan to link the fleet with Parma extremely risky?

"Treaty of Nonsuch (1585): Dudley's 7,400 troops in the Netherlands made war with Spain inevitable."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 18 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 2 (1HI0/2B) Score: / 12

Explain why England became involved in the Netherlands in 1585. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer: • The assassination of William of Orange • The Treaty of Joinville *(You must also use information of your own.)*

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:
One main reason was that... • For example, ... • This was important because... • Another key factor was... • In particular, ... • Overall, the most decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:
Treaty of Nonsuch (1585) • Robert Dudley (Earl of Leicester) • 7,400 English Troops • Duke of Parma • Spanish Netherlands • Deep-Water Ports • French Catholic League • Protestant Rebels • Flushing and Brill

Write your response in the space provided below: *(Response continues on facing page)*

Enquiry 2.3: Outbreak of war with Spain, 1585–88 • Question 2 Explain Why Continued

Score: / 12

Conclude your question 2 explain why and provide your sustained historical verdict below:

• QUESTION 1 PRACTICE: DESCRIBE ONE FEATURE [2 × 2M = 4 MARKS • 6 MINS]

Q1 Total: / 4

Q1(A) **EDEXCEL NOVEMBER 2020 (Q1B)** **Mark: / 2**

Describe one feature of the Treaty of Nonsuch (1585). [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this was evident when...*

Q1(B) **EDEXCEL JUNE 2022 (Q1A)** **Mark: / 2**

Describe one feature of Robert Dudley's campaign in the Netherlands. [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this meant that...*

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Milestone 3). In Milestone 3, sketch English troops landing at Flushing with the flags of the Dutch Protestant rebels. ← **Pages 2–3**

"Tactical breakdown: English race-built galleons versus high Spanish castles in the Channel duel."

Did brilliant English tactics or fatal Spanish blunders defeat the Armada in 1588?

1 JULY 1588

Channel Battles: Plymouth to Isle of Wight

- Seven-Mile Crescent Defensive Line
- Long-Range Culverin Duel Beyond Boarding
- Prevented Landing on Isle of Wight

Why were English ships unable to break the Armada's crescent formation in open Channel water?

2 7–8 AUG 1588

Calais Roads & The Fireships

- Eight Pitch-Soaked Vessels at Midnight
- Panic-Stricken Spanish Ships Cut Anchors
- Shattered Crescent Never Reforms

Why did the English use of fireships at Calais prove the decisive turning point of the campaign?

3 8 AUG 1588

The Battle of Gravelines

- Hawkins' Low Race-Built Galleons
- Rapid-Fire Broadside Gunnery Close Range
- Three Galleons Sunk & Fleet Scattered

How did English ship design and gunnery tactics defeat Spanish warships at Gravelines?

4 AUG–SEPT 1588

The Winds & Atlantic Retreat

- Gale-Force 'Protestant Wind' Drives North
- Missing Anchors on Scottish & Irish Reefs
- Only Sixty-Seven Battered Ships Return

Why did the combination of adverse weather and lost equipment destroy the retreating Armada?

5 1588–1589

Consequences of the English Victory

- Tilbury Speech: 'Heart & Stomach of a King'
- 'God Blew and They Were Scattered' Medals
- English Naval Superpower Prestige Secured

How did the defeat of the Armada transform Elizabeth's reputation at home and abroad?

Question 3: Evaluative Essay [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG • 25 mins]

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 (1HI0/2B)

Score: / 20

"The tactics of the English navy were the main reason for the defeat of the Spanish Armada." How far do you agree? Explain your answer. [16 marks + 4 marks SPaG]

You may use in your answer: • Fireships at Calais • The weather ***(You must also use information of your own.)***

ACCESSIBLE WRITING FRAMES:

To a large extent, it can be argued that... • A decisive factor supporting this view was... • Specifically, this was important because... • On the other hand, an alternative perspective is that... • In particular, ... • In conclusion, the decisive reason was... because...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

Duke of Medina Sidonia • Crescent Formation • Calais Roads Midnight • 8 English Fireships • Battle of Gravelines • Race-Built Galleons • Rapid-Fire Culverins • Parma's Invasion Barges • Protestant Wind

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on facing page)

"Battle of Gravelines: Agile English galleons with rapid-fire culverins smashed the drifting Spanish fleet."

Score: / 20

Conclude your question 3 evaluative essay and provide your sustained historical verdict below:

• QUESTION 1 PRACTICE: DESCRIBE ONE FEATURE [2 × 2M = 4 MARKS • 6 MINS]

Q1 Total: / 4

Q1(A) EDEXCEL JUNE 2019 (Q1B) — Mark: / 2

Describe one feature of the Spanish Armada's crescent formation. [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this was evident when...*

Q1(B) EDEXCEL JUNE 2021 (Q1B) — Mark: / 2

Describe one feature of English naval tactics during the Armada campaign. [2 marks]

Target: AO1 (2m) • *Feature: One key feature was that... • Detail: Specifically, this meant that...*

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Milestone 4). In Milestone 4, sketch the English fireships drifting into the Spanish fleet at Calais Roads. ← Pages 2–3

PUPIL: _____ **TARGET GRADE:** ☐ **PREDICTED:** ☐ **ATTITUDE:** 1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5

MASTER EXAM PRACTICE & HOMEWORK ASSESSMENT TRACKER • KEY TOPIC 2

#	ENQUIRY & SPECIFICATION TOPIC	PAGE	EXAM PRACTICE QUESTION & FOCUS	HOMEWORK DEADLINE	MARK AWARDED
2.1	ENQUIRY 2.1: PLOTS AND REVOLTS AT HOME, 1569–87 Spine Lecture Notes (p. 4): / 10	p. 5–6	**Q2 Explain Why:** Explain why Mary, Queen of Scots was executed in 1587. [12 marks] [12m]	___/___	/ 12
		p. 6	**Q1(a) Feature:** the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569) [2m]		/ 2
		p. 6	**Q1(b) Feature:** the Babington Plot (1586) [2m]		/ 2
		Summary	Total Module Enquiry Assessment Mark		/ 16
2.2	ENQUIRY 2.2: RELATIONS WITH SPAIN AND COMMERCIAL RIVALRY Spine Lecture Notes (p. 7): / 10	p. 8–9	**Q3 Essay:** "Commercial rivalry was the main cause of conflict between England ... [20m]	___/___	/ 20
		p. 9	**Q1(a) Feature:** English privateering against Spain [2m]		/ 2
		p. 9	**Q1(b) Feature:** Francis Drake's raid on Cadiz (1587) [2m]		/ 2
		Summary	Total Module Enquiry Assessment Mark		/ 24
2.3	ENQUIRY 2.3: OUTBREAK OF WAR WITH SPAIN, 1585–88 Spine Lecture Notes (p. 10): / 10	p. 11–12	**Q2 Explain Why:** Explain why England became involved in the Netherlands in 1585. [12... [12m]	___/___	/ 12
		p. 12	**Q1(a) Feature:** the Treaty of Nonsuch (1585) [2m]		/ 2
		p. 12	**Q1(b) Feature:** Robert Dudley's campaign in the Netherlands [2m]		/ 2
		Summary	Total Module Enquiry Assessment Mark		/ 16
2.4	ENQUIRY 2.4: THE SPANISH ARMADA, 1588 Spine Lecture Notes (p. 13): / 10	p. 14–15	**Q3 Essay:** "The tactics of the English navy were the main reason for the defea... [20m]	___/___	/ 20
		p. 15	**Q1(a) Feature:** the Spanish Armada's crescent formation [2m]		/ 2
		p. 15	**Q1(b) Feature:** English naval tactics during the Armada campaign [2m]		/ 2
		Summary	Total Module Enquiry Assessment Mark		/ 24

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ENQUIRY 2.1
Plots and revolts at home, 1569–87
Revolt of the Northern Earls • 1569

LESSON — Read Online
20-Q QUIZ — Self-Marking

Quiz Attempt: [ ] 1st [ ] 2nd [ ] 3rd
Score: / 20 Date: ___/___

ENQUIRY 2.2
Relations with Spain and commer...
Political and religious rivalry • co...

LESSON — Read Online
20-Q QUIZ — Self-Marking

Quiz Attempt: [ ] 1st [ ] 2nd [ ] 3rd
Score: / 20 Date: ___/___

ENQUIRY 2.3
Outbreak of war with Spain, 1585–...
English involvement in the Netherlands &...

LESSON — Read Online
20-Q QUIZ — Self-Marking

Quiz Attempt: [ ] 1st [ ] 2nd [ ] 3rd
Score: / 20 Date: ___/___

ENQUIRY 2.4
The Spanish Armada, 1588
Reasons why Philip II launched the Arma...

LESSON — Read Online
20-Q QUIZ — Self-Marking

Quiz Attempt: [ ] 1st [ ] 2nd [ ] 3rd
Score: / 20 Date: ___/___